

# THE ROLE OF SUPPORT STRUCTURES IN FACILITATING GRADUATE TRANSITIONS THROUGH LEARNERSHIP PROGRAMMES IN SOUTH AFRICA

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## Abstract

This paper aims to explore how support structures are utilised to assist graduates in navigating the transition through learnership programmes in South Africa. While support structures in learnerships are acknowledged as necessary, their specific role in graduate transitions and development remains under-researched. The overarching question is: How do institutional support structures enable or constrain graduate development within learnership programmes? The qualitative approach was employed, relying on responses to open-ended questionnaires and three focus group interviews with graduates from two organisations that provide learnerships. The study draws on qualitative data from 74 graduates, including 64 respondents to open-ended questionnaires and 10 participants in three focus group interviews. Thematic analysis of the data was employed to identify patterns of support structure and the gaps present. The results indicate that support in the form of induction, the provision of laptops and workstations, the assignment of mentors, effective communication with supervisors, and assignment to real working environments met expectations, alleviated anxiety, and facilitated a successful transition. These support structures were primarily accessed by employed learnership participants and were utilised to varying degrees across organisational. The results also reveal that inadequate planning, the absence of workplace placement, and inadequate support in balancing study and employment led to negative experiences and undermined the benefits of employability. This paper argues that support should be planned and staffed as a central part of learnerships, and that it be coordinated between providers and host employers in a way that benefits everyone equally from the programme and ensures learnerships meet their transition requirements. The support structures examined were embedded within institutionally coordinated learnership programmes and financed through a combination of organisational resources and national skills development funding mechanisms.

Keywords: Graduate transitions; Learnership programmes; Support structures; Employability development.

## 1 INTRODUCTION

South Africa's Graduate learnership programmes have emerged as a significant channel for helping unemployed graduates integrate into the labour market, especially when formal qualifications have failed to secure them employment. Although such programmes are designed to incorporate structured education with workplace exposure, not all graduates undergo this transition process equally. Research shows that when support structures are in place, responsive, and transparent, graduates report integrating more easily, experiencing less anxiety, and developing stronger employability skills (Nkwanyane et al., 2022; Winberg et al., 2022). This supports South African claims that learnerships can only work as labour-market interventions when the broader skills system facilitates participation, not because the qualification will do so on its own. (Allais, 2022). In the absence of support, the same programme design can be challenging to navigate, and in some cases, perceived as ineffective. This implies that support does not play a peripheral role, but is a fundamental facilitator of learnership effectiveness.

The current literature on graduate employability in South Africa has given considerable attention to skill development, workplace exposure, and the outcomes of workplace programmes. This is a significant gap considering that recent empirical scholarly work on South Africa and WIL has primarily predetermined skills development and exposure (Winberg et al., 2020; Mayombe, 2023), and system-level skills interventions (Allais, 2022), whereas very little energy has been put into the mediating role of institutional, organisational, and interpersonal support of such outcomes. Learnership should demonstrate various types of support, including induction, mentoring, access to work materials, openness to communication with supervisors, and emotional or psychosocial support. Such sources of support contribute to the realisation of expectations, to gaining control over learning and work activities, and to gaining confidence in professional areas. On the other hand, gaps such as inadequate placement,

poor planning, failure to communicate, and insufficient supervisory direction limit their growth and, in some instances, may compromise the learnership's objectives.

Support structures are considered a focal point of analysis, rather than a peripheral component of programme delivery. The overarching question is: How do institutional support systems facilitate or limit graduate development in learnership programmes? The paper argues that successful transitions are not possible without effective support structures, which, in turn, are central to the design, resources, and monitoring of learnerships, as the graduates themselves narrate the support they receive.

## **2 METHODOLOGY**

This paper is grounded in a qualitative research methodology from 74 respondents generated through two main instruments: (1) open-ended survey questions (OEQs) comprising 64 respondents, and (2) three sets of focused group discussions (FGDs). The FGDs comprised three respondents in the first set, three in the second, and four in the third, each contributing distinctive perspectives. Together, these sources capture rich narratives of learners' and graduates' experiences in work-based learning. By narrowing the scope to qualitative evidence, this paper highlights the depth of participant reflections on identity negotiation and support structures within learnerships.

The analysis of this data set was conducted using thematic analysis, which enabled the systematic identification, organisation, and interpretation of patterns across the qualitative evidence. Responses to the open-ended questions and FGDs were coded iteratively, and key themes were constructed to reflect recurring concerns, tensions, and insights. These themes are supported by direct quotes from the data, ensuring that participants' voices remain central to the discussion.

### **2.1 Ethical considerations**

Approval to conduct this study was obtained from the Human Research Ethics Committee (Non-Medical) of the University of the Witwatersrand, Johannesburg. Voluntary consent was obtained from the participants via a consent form. All 74 respondents (64 OEQs and 10 FGDs) confirmed that they had read and fully understood the consent form and that they willingly chose to participate in this research study.

## **3 RESULTS AND DISCUSSION**

### **3.1 Support mechanisms and their influence on learning outcomes**

As indicated in the research's qualitative data, the presence or absence of support structures determined the extent to which graduates could learn, cope, and acquire employability skills. The process of learning was not explained as an automatic event but rather defined as a reality that occurred when learners were directed, supported, and placed in conditions that allowed them to be fully engaged. In those areas, graduates claimed that the programme was less cumbersome to follow, expectations were more clearly spelt out, and they could complete the theory and work-based parts. This is evidenced by findings that strong support from graduates led to expectations being managed, reduced anxiety, and a generally easier transition.

One of the key aspects that supported the affected individuals was the management of the two-fold task load between course and workplace tasks. This aligns with work-integrated learning research, which indicates that well-coordinated and organised support helps students manage the combined demands of employment and learning, promoting positive outcomes (Winberg et al., 2022; Mbele & Swart, 2024). Some participants noted that the first year of the learnership was challenging, as they had to adapt to working full-time while also completing assessments. Supervisory communication and clarity were helpful. This was explained by one of the participants, who explained the difficulty and then how they managed the situation with support. The participant stated that

"It was overwhelming for me to deal with both the department work tasks and the tasks from the course I have been enrolled in. However, eventually, I overcame this challenge by keeping an open line of communication with the manager of the department and seeking clarity on what is expected of me and how I will manage my time to accommodate both."

Another learner confirmed that balancing work and study was a real source of pressure. The learner noted that:

"Working and studying. I had to balance the academic component and job experience."

These two accounts show that communication with line managers and clarity of expectations functioned as a form of instructional support. Once learners understood what was expected, they could plan time, complete assessments, and remain in the programme.

Material and structural support also influenced learning, as graduates noted that being given the right tools and placed in real work teams enabled them to learn and feel they belonged in the organisation. The data is presented

in the following line, which shows the importance of resources and mentoring. It is stated that:

“Graduates in the study emphasised the importance of being allocated work resources like laptops, workstations, mentors and participating in real work.”

This means that support was not only emotional but also practical. If a learner did not have a workplace or did not receive a laptop, there were fewer opportunities to practise employability skills. The exact section of the data links the unavailability of workplaces to negative experiences, indicating again that placement itself is a support requirement.

Emotional and transition support were described as equally important. For many learners, this was the first time they were operating as both workers and students simultaneously. One focus group participant explained the weight of this period. The participant said that:

“When it began, it was quite a challenge, because now I had to juggle between, like, work and studying and completing assessments.”

Another participant provided more details on the programme's intensity and the extra effort required after hours. The participant said that:

“The way the leadership is structured, the amount of work that is required ... It was a lot ... so I had to make sure that after work then I do my learnership work ...”

These two quotes demonstrate that programmes require support from supervisors, and the programme structure helps prevent drop-out and frustration.

A final point that emerged was that alignment between the learning content and workplace tasks also acted as a form of support. One learner explained that the theory component did not always relate to their daily work, which made completion difficult. The learner said that:

“I was not really interested because it didn't, most of the things in it didn't relate to what I was doing on a daily basis. So I think that's why I couldn't complete it.”

It demonstrates that aligning curriculum with the workplace facilitates motivation and more in-depth learning (Winberg et al., 2020; Mbele & Swart, 2024). The support mechanisms that contributed to improved learning outcomes in the learnership programme included clear communication, provision of resources, mentoring, emotional reassurance, and meaningful placement.

### **3.2 Forms of support graduates identify as most crucial for their transition**

The research demonstrates that the graduates did not see all types of support as equivalent. Some of the supports were reported as nice-to-haves, while others were reported as necessary to help learners cope with the learning, understand what is expected, and how the learnership was developed. The support forms that were recurrently prioritised were early induction, availability of workplace resources, mentorship or supervisory assistance, exposure to meaningful workplace tasks, clear communication channels and emotional or psychosocial support. These were the pillars that helped graduates adjust, understand what to do, feel like a part of it, and make the programme activities contribute to employability development.

The results showed that Graduates valued programme factors that equipped them initially. It is stated that:

“These services encompass informative induction programmes, provision of technical resources such as laptops and workstations, allocation of human resources such as mentors, exposure to meaningful work experiences, and opportunities for network building.”

This line suggests that interpersonal support was not the only important factor; structural support was significant as well. The programme was explained through induction; participation was facilitated through resources; mentors were involved to guide the individual; and the real work made it possible to apply the learning. When these existed initially, the transition was considered smoother. This was established

later in the same document, where it was noted that the support implemented at the beginning of the programme was stabilising. It is reported that:

“Support structures established at the beginning of the programme... managed expectations, decreased anxieties, and overall smoother transitions.”

This means that timing matters. Support that arrives early has more impact than reactive support.

Access to resources was also found to be vital to the graduates, as many were moving into workplaces where making fruitful contributions requires a laptop, a workstation, and appropriate software. In their absence, they felt like outcasts in the team activities. The previous statement mentions the supply of technical equipment, such as laptops and workstations; this was not an extravagance but a fundamental necessity for studying and integration.

Another powerful priority was human assistance, the mentors and supervisors. This aligns with the South African WIL study evidence, which suggests that access to engaged supervisors and mentors is pivotal to transforming workplace exposure into tangible gains in employability (Nkwanyane et al., 2022; Winberg et al., 2022). Some of the graduates noted that they addressed the workload by speaking with a manager, who clarified the workload and provided guidance on how to balance it. One graduate described how communication with the department manager helped make the transition manageable. The graduate said that:

“Keeping an open line of communication with the manager of the department and seeking clarity of what is expected of me...”

This shows that supervision was not only about checking performance. It was also about providing interpretive support, helping the learner understand what the organisation wanted and how to schedule their time effectively.

Emotional and psychosocial support were identified as important because the transition into the workplace was described as overwhelming for some. The document notes that:

“Addressing unspoken anxieties and providing emotional support can ease the transition into the workplace.”

This implies that graduates were not only required to have technical training. They required consolation, an appreciation of their plight, and a person to guide them through the new organisational cultures. This is even more relevant when graduates need to transition to the programme, as the document states, which increases the importance of the support they receive at the beginning.

The results indicated that exposure to meaningful work was a type of support that the graduates found beneficial. Their placement in an actual workplace, working on real assignments and being permitted to contribute allowed them to view themselves as professionals and make the connection between theory and practice. This was enumerated under the same bracket of support services, alongside induction and mentoring, which demonstrates that learners not only viewed placement as an opportunity but also as a form of support.

The supports that were most important in transitioning learners were those that equipped them at an early stage, enabled them to be involved, mentored them through supervisors, identified their emotional needs, and placed them in actual work to enable them to practise employability skills. The latter is justified by the fact that the well-prepared, resourceful, and closely monitored work-integrated learning placements, particularly those that are attentive to the socio-emotional needs of the students, are the ones that are most successful in achieving employability outcomes in South African settings (Mayombe, 2023; Winberg et al., 2022).

### **3.3 Gaps in current support provisions**

The qualitative data also demonstrates that the support in the learnership programmes was not always adequate, timely or consistent. The graduates identified various points that were either unsupported or poorly supported, enabling them to cope with the transition into the workforce. These loopholes directly affected their learning, confidence, and ability to complete the programme. The most significant gaps were inadequate or insufficient planning, a deficiency in workplace placement, insufficient support to balance school and employment, a poor match between learning materials and job responsibilities, and a disparate focus on the emotional needs of transition. The same gaps can be observed in South Africa work integrated learning studies that report that a lack of proper planning curtails or lacks placements that would provide adequate guidance on managing dual demands and imbalanced alignment between

curriculum and workplace activities, making employability programmes less effective and ignoring the affective needs of students (Allais, 2022; Winberg et al., 2022; Mbele & Swart, 2024).

The findings state that planning issues and a lack of organisational learning in the workplace are already recognised in the field as causes of learnerships not always being successful. It is stated that:

“Unfortunately, the literature frequently cites poor planning and the unavailability of workplace learning as being among the key reasons for learnership fails.”

This statement shows that the problem is not only individual but also systemic. When the workplace component is not organised, the programme loses its key site of learning. The same dataset links this to the experiences of graduates in this study. It notes that

The unavailability of workplaces was found to be associated with negative experiences among graduates in this study. Thus, the significance of workplaces as an important location for developing employability skills is explained.

This implies that omission of placement is not a minor detail. It eliminates the very context within which learners are training communication, teamwork and professional behaviour.

The other gap detected by graduates was the challenge of balancing program requirements with work tasks. Some interviewees stated that they were under pressure because of doing department work and completing course assessments simultaneously. The load proved to be a drag, where there was no intervention by supervisors to assist in prioritising and scheduling. One graduate spoke about the difficulty with no wording. The graduate said that:

“Back to back assessments, having little time to prepare was a challenge...”

This shows that programme pacing and workload management were not always supported. A related extract in the same section explains that participants sometimes had to manage multiple roles, and it is unclear whether the programme support was sufficient for this.

This raises questions about the adequacy of the support provided to balance the demands of their work and learning commitments.

This is an important gap because the entire model of a learnership rests on the assumption that learners can work and learn simultaneously. If there is no structured support to balance the two, the model becomes hard for graduates to sustain.

There were also gaps related to learners' broader circumstances. Some graduates had to relocate closer to their workplace, which added social and financial pressure. The document notes that graduates who relocate depend even more on institutional and workplace support. It states that

“Graduates... may even relocate to be closer to their workplace, magnifying the significance of the support they receive at the outset.”

If such support is not present early, these graduates experience transition as stressful than enabling factor.

Another difference was that certain support was generic and not tailored to specific needs. The research itself acknowledges that it did not delve deeply into the issues of balancing the various identities participants encountered, which is why existing assistance may not fully grasp the complexity of graduates' experiences. This implies that support systems may need to be more differentiated and sensitive to learners' diverse circumstances.

These results indicate that the primary gaps in support are the absence or delay of workplace placements, the inadequacy of assistance with workloads and role management, the insufficiency of initial support for relocating people, and insufficient awareness of the emotional and identity work involved in the transition. These loopholes diminished the developmental value of the learnership for some learners and suggest that support structures should be developed as fundamental aspects of programme design and incorporated into programme implementation, rather than implemented in an ad hoc manner. The qualitative study has yielded new results, summarised in Table 1 below and supported by quotes.

**Table 1:** Summary of emerging findings and their illustrative quotes

| Objective of the study                                                                                        | Key emerging findings                                                                                                                                                                                                               | Illustrative Quotes                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Support mechanisms influence learning outcomes in graduate learnership programmes</b>                      | Early and structured support improves the transition; supervisory communication helps balance work and study; material and placement support enable participation; emotional support reduces anxiety.                               | “Graduates received robust support witnessed managed expectations, decreased anxieties, and overall smoother transitions.” “It was overwhelming for me to deal with both the department work tasks and the tasks from the course I have been enrolled in. But eventually, I overcame this challenge by keeping an open line of communication with the manager of the department and seeking clarity of what is expected of me and how will I manage my time to accommodate both.” “Working and studying. I had to balance the academic component and job experience.” “Graduates in the study emphasised the importance of being allocated work resources like laptops, workstations, mentors and participating in real work.” “When it began, it was quite a challenge, because now I had to juggle between, like, work and studying and completing assessments.”                  |
| <b>Forms of support that graduates regard as most crucial for a successful transition during learnerships</b> | Induction at the start of the programme; Access to tools and workstations; Mentoring and clear communication; Meaningful workplace exposure; Emotional and relational support                                                       | “These services encompass informative induction programmes, provision of technical resources such as laptops and workstations, allocation of human resources such as mentors, exposure to meaningful work experiences, and opportunities for network building.” “Support structures established at the beginning of the programme... managed expectations, decreased anxieties, and overall smoother transitions.” “Keeping an open line of communication with the manager of the department and seeking clarity of what is expected of me...” “Addressing unspoken anxieties and providing emotional support can ease the transition into the workplace.” “Graduates... may even relocate to be closer to their workplace, magnifying the significance of the support they receive at the outset.”                                                                                 |
| <b>Gaps and constraints in current support provisions within learnership programmes</b>                       | Poor or late planning; Absence or shortage of workplace placement; Inadequate workload and role balancing support; Misalignment between programme and work; Insufficiently differentiated support for diverse learner circumstances | “Unfortunately, the literature frequently cites poor planning and the unavailability of workplace learning as being among the key reasons for learnership fails.” “This study found a relationship between the unavailability of workplaces with graduates’ negative experiences, underscoring the importance of workplaces as key sites of employability skills development.” “Back to back assessments, having little time to prepare was a challenge...” “This raises questions about the adequacy of support provided... to balance the demands of their work and learning commitments effectively.” “Graduates... may even relocate to be closer to their workplace, magnifying the significance of the support they receive at the outset.” “The study failed to delve deeper into the challenges participants faced in balancing the demands of their various identities...” |

## 4 CONCLUSION

The results indicate that support structures are not peripheral appendages to graduate learnership programmes. Graduates reported experiencing less anxiety, clearer expectations, and greater involvement in both academic and workplace activities when support was provided early in their studies through induction, resource provision, mentoring, and effective communication. In a few situations where learners could not secure workplace placements or receive adequate workload support, the programme proved challenging and incomplete, thereby undermining the gains in employability. It was also found that emotional and psychosocial support would be relevant to assist first-time entrants in adapting to organisational cultures. Such trends suggest that a structured, timely, and context-sensitive support can help graduates transform programme activities into actual skill development. The paper thus argues that support must be methodically integrated into the design of the learnership, coordinated between the provider and employer, and tracked as a fundamental quality dimension, if such programmes are to achieve their aim of enhancing graduate transitions in South Africa.

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